Chapter 7

The End of Scorekeeping

Somewhere inside you, there's a running total. You didn't sit down and decide to keep it. You just know where you stand.

The fix.

The internet goes down on a Tuesday night, mid-show, and you're the one who gets up. You reset the router, check the cables, call the provider, wait on hold, get it working again. Nobody asks you to do this. It's just yours, and so is the TV that needed a new setting after the last software update. You know your way around the house's machinery. So it falls to you, quietly, the way certain jobs usually fall to whoever can do them.

A few weeks before that, you spent an entire weekend at a tournament three hours away, coaching your kid's team. You handled the snacks, the rides and a hotel room. She stayed home and ran the rest of life without you. Both of those were real. Both took something out of you. And if anyone ever asked you to make the case for how much you give this marriage, those are the two stories you'd tell. They're the ones with a beginning, an end, and a name.

The dozens of smaller things neither of you tracks, on either side, wouldn't make your list. You didn't ask a question because you already knew the answer would start something. You spent five minutes finding her keys. You noticed she hadn't eaten and, without saying anything about it, handed her a plate. None of those would register if someone asked you to defend yourself. They're too small, too constant, too easy to forget you even did them.

More than chores.

Marriages keep score on more than who did the dishes. Some couples tally whose income or whose caretaking counts as the real contribution. Some tally who sacrificed more: a birth, a career, a move. Some tally who's better at what, who's been hurt worse, who tries harder in the relationship. The currencies differ, but the instinct is the same: you know where you stand the way you know your bank balance without checking it. This chapter goes deep on one version of that instinct, the oldest and most common one, the one about labor. Once you can see why it fails, you'll recognize the same failure wherever else you're running a private count.

Two honest ledgers.

Picture a jar filled with rocks. A few big ones go in first. Those are the visible contributions with a clear edge and a story attached. Think of fixing the router, the coaching weekend, the day you took off work for the family. They're real, and they matter. But they don't fill the jar. What fills most of the space is sand: hundreds of small acts done without tracking them, poured in beneath and around and on top. They make up the majority of what's actually there. The big contributions are easy to count, easy to remember and easy to bring up in an argument. The small ones are everything else, and there's far more of them.

This is why the math never works when either of you tries to do it. You can list the things you did. She can list hers. Neither of you can list the small ones, because they're too small to register while they're happening, even for the person doing them. Any tally you keep is built only from the visible things. Those are the smallest part of what's actually happening, and you mistake them for the whole.

My grandfather had a piece of marriage advice he gave me once, and I've never forgotten it: give 60 percent, expect 40 percent. Not 50-50. Sixty-forty.

He wasn't doing arithmetic. He was naming the only posture that survives a total neither of you can fully see. If you're only willing to give what you expect back in equal measure, you'll spend your marriage chasing a balance. That balance was never visible to begin with. You can only count what you remember, and what you remember was never the whole picture.

There's a researcher named Karl Pillemer who spent years asking more than seven hundred people who'd been married thirty years or more what actually worked. Almost none of them talked about splitting things evenly. The phrase that kept coming up instead was some version of "give more than you get." That phrase is the pattern long marriages report when they look back on their own years. A separate, much larger study, thirteen years of data on more than 7,000 couples in Germany, found something that points in the same direction. People who kept close track of what they were owed, expecting their giving to be matched back, saw their satisfaction erode over time. Most couples loosen that expectation naturally as the relationship deepens. The ones who don't tend to drift.

To be fair, none of that means the imbalance you feel is imaginary. Sometimes one person really is carrying more, and that's worth naming. What it does mean is that the running tally in your head isn't a reliable way to find out whether that's true. It can only show you the smallest, most visible slice of the work, and it will tell you that you're ahead. Your own invisible contributions are just as invisible to you as hers are to her. Figuring out whether an imbalance is real takes a different kind of looking: an honest, deliberate accounting rather than a private one. That's the next chapter's work. This one is about why the private tally can't do it.

Whose column is this.

Ask the old sorting question again: is this yours to control, or isn't it? Her effort and her noticing aren't yours to control. What you give, and how you

give it: that's the only column with your name on it.

None of this means giving up. You can still name an unfairness or ask for something different. The private tally was just never the right tool for finding a real imbalance. A tally that can only read your own side, built from contributions you happened to notice and remember, will usually tell you you're ahead. It's arithmetic done on one page of a two-page ledger.

You can ask for what you need. You can have the conversation about what's unfair. But the private count of who's ahead was never yours to settle alone, because it was never just your column to keep.

Seneca wrote at length in *De Beneficiis*, his work on the philosophy of giving and receiving. In it he asks why the person who receives a gift always underestimates what they've been given. His answer: you can never fully see everything that went into what someone gave you. Flip that around: when you receive what she gives, you're seeing the finished thing and missing everything that produced it. Gratitude for more than you can see is the only honest response to a ledger you can't fully read.

Marcus Aurelius put it plainly: when you've done something good, why look for credit beyond the act, or wait to see what comes back? There's the doing, and there's the need it met. That's the whole list. Don't reach for the third thing.

The reconstruction.

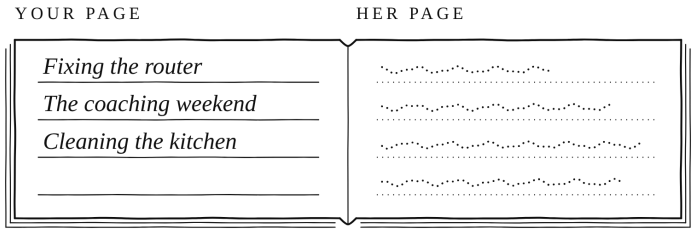
Try this sometime when you're turning over a feeling of unfairness, the kind that shows up quietly, days later, while you're driving or half-listening to something else. Instead of running your own tally again, try running hers. Skip the dramatic version. Go small. What did she carry today that you didn't see her carry? What did she notice so you didn't have to? What question did she not ask, the same way you didn't ask yours?

You'll find you can't finish the list. Your memory isn't failing you. You're running into the same invisible weight from her side, and it's just as hard to count as yours. You aren't trying to rebuild her side better than she could rebuild yours. You're trying to feel, for a minute, how much of what she gives was never going to make it onto anyone's list, including her own.

Give 60 percent, expect 40: not because the math is fair, but because no math was ever going to find the bottom of that jar.

The Private Tally

The ledger can only count what it can see.



a ledger you can't fully read



the smaller things neither of you tracks

Half the data, and it
always says you're ahead.

Putting into Practice

Chapter 7 — The End of Scorekeeping

Mechanism: The Private Tally

The idea in one sentence: The ledger you keep in your head can only count the visible things, so it was always going to tell you that you're ahead.

Most husbands run a private tally of who's given more, but the tally is built entirely from contributions big enough to remember: the smallest fraction of what's actually there. The Stoic answer: stay in your own column, give more than you expect back, and practice gratitude for what you can't count.

Lesson: The Stoics built their ethics on one question: is this mine to control, or isn't it? Applied here, the only column with your name on it is what you give and how you give it. Not what you're owed back for it.

Challenge: Believing you're keeping an honest tally of who's given more, when that tally only ever had access to half the data: your side, not hers.

PRACTICE

1. When a feeling of unfairness surfaces, try running her tally instead of yours: go small. What did she carry today that you didn't see her carry?
2. Notice which currency you're actually tallying: whose income or caretaking counts as the real contribution, who sacrificed more (a birth, a career, a move), or who tries harder. Then ask honestly whether your count has ever included what she'd list, not just what you would.
3. This week, aim to give at a level where you're not tracking what comes back. Notice what changes when you loosen the expectation.